



BACK VIEW



SIDE VIEW

Wide hips created by the hooped petticoat worn underneath



ANGLED SIDE VIEW

Skirt constructed from narrow widths of fabric sewn together



IN DETAIL



◁ STOMACHER

The triangular piece of fabric worn centre front – the stomacher – was first pinned to the stays (a heavily boned underbodice) before the gown was pulled into position and secured with pins. Diamonds might adorn the stomacher on grand occasions.



◁ CENTRE BACK SEAM

The silk has been carefully pieced together so that the pattern is mirrored on either side of the central seam that runs down the back of the gown. The mantua developed from a loose gown that was originally draped into graceful pleats before these came to be stitched into position. The arrangement of fabric at the back of the waist alludes to earlier incarnations of the mantua gown. These would have had their open skirts swathed towards the back, where a long train was looped up and arranged in pleats.



◁ SLEEVE RUFFLES

During the 1740s deep sleeve cuffs were replaced with ruffles, usually worn in three layers. Sometimes a lead weight, the size of a large coin and covered in fabric, was attached inside the bottom of the sleeve to prevent it from riding up.



◁ BROCADE

The silk is brocaded, which means that the complicated pattern was woven into the fabric, rather than embroidered onto it. At least 14 different colours and four types of silver thread were used, reflecting the light in different ways and sparkling beautifully in candlelight.